

QUESTION

a special category after the Jat agitation in 2016, but the move was struck down by court

Muslim groups are periodically added to central or state OBC lists without assigning any fixed quota. In Bihar, for instance, there are about 25 such caste groups in the central OBC list. Madhya Pradesh lists 20-odd caste groups, including Hajjam, Mochi, Luhar and Banjara. Among the states that follow this model is Gujarat, which has several Muslim OBC groups

But, in West Bengal, the Left and TMC governments tried to push the envelope and included 106 Muslim groups among OBCs through executive orders and a legislation in 2010 and 2012. The Calcutta HC has now annulled these, stating that "the said community has been treated as a commodity for political ends"

oned, would bear some pain and still be loyal. But this vital buffer had to be protected at all cost. Perhaps dangling another threat to their reservation space would work.

This is where the BJP leaders, with PM Modi leading a supercharged counter-attack, sought immunity by adding religion to the mix, confounding the narrative by invoking the Muslim spectre. The Congress's promised "X-ray of India" was meant to purloin all assets and rights—from the "*mangalsutra*" of Hindu women to existing caste quotas—and parcel it out to Muslims, Modi said. Muslim reservations were one of the oldest riddles within the OBC black box. Modi and the BJP pushed it centre stage and revived the old charge of appeasement against the Congress. They worked on a twin strategy. The Congress manifesto and Rahul Gandhi's theme of wealth redistribution were linked to a Muslim-first policy. Then the past actions of a few Congress-led state governments, which had pushed for Muslim reservations, helped establish a pattern of conduct. As Exhibit A, they pulled out a 2006 statement by then PM Dr Manmohan Singh, ascribing to it an intent to give Muslims the "first claim" on India's resources. There was also the Congress's old ambivalence. Dr K. Laxman, president, BJP OBC Morcha, recalled Nehru's 1961 letter to chief ministers where he expressed discomfort with caste-based reservations, saying he was opposed to anything that could lead to "inefficiency and second-grade standards".

THE COMMUNAL SHIFT

The BJP's strategy of shifting the reservation debate to one on Muslim appeasement had the Congress on the back foot. The party clarified that Manmohan's remarks were part of a 'collective expression' that included the OBCs, Dalits and Adivasis besides the minorities and said isolated focus on the latter, shorn of context, was a wilful distortion. It also doubled down on the national caste census: its manifesto had promised to embed it within a wider socio-economic survey—"based on the data, we would strengthen the agenda for affirmative action." Paired with that was the pledge to pass a constitutional amendment to lift the 50 per cent ceiling on reservations, held sacrosanct since the Supreme Court's post-Mandal Indra Sawhney judgment of 1992. Former Union home minister P. Chidambaram, who co-authored the party manifesto, denies any internal disagreement over these promises. "Nobody is ambivalent within the Congress," he tells INDIA TODAY. "For various reasons, governments of the day did not consider asking a question on caste in the census from 1951 to 2011. Then the demand arose. If we had been in power, we would have included that question in the 2021 census."

There is nothing in the Congress manifesto to suggest affirmative action, including taking *mangalsutras* and handing it to Muslims, as the PM had claimed. In fact, the document carefully skirts around the word 'Muslim' altogether. One implicit allusion to them comes where the manifesto promises to



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"RESERVATION IS FOR DALITS WHAT LAND IS FOR THE FARMER. THEY WILL NOT PERMIT OR TOLERATE EVEN THE SLIGHTEST POSSIBILITY OF THAT BEING TOUCHED"